He recalls that Batliwala was like a ‘mother’ to him, and he had also met Krishna Kumar whose words, ‘The doors of the Taj are always open for you’, still ring in his ears. On his discharge from the navy, the Tatas employed Praveen in their security establishment. He has since branched out to start his own training programme. The Tatas continue to assist him. Recalling all the assistance the TPSWT gave him, Praveen says, ‘Ratan Tata is a great man’ and ‘I have no words to describe their help’.

Because of his empathy and closeness to his colleagues, as also employees from all strata, Ratan understood that after a traumatic event, besides the extension of relief, it was equally important to address the psychological and emotional health of the survivors. Post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) might surface in the victims at any time, even long after the occurrence of the event. Therefore, he requisitioned the services of fifteen experts for post-trauma counselling.

This was ‘really very important’ for those who had suffered the most, feels Thevar. He too used to get nightmares and was troubled by the blood-curdling memories. To help with this, the Tatas even went to the extent of giving him a change of environment by posting him at the Taj Exotica in the Maldives. It was like a holiday that helped him immensely to overcome his anxieties. Though he chose to leave the Taj when better prospects came his way, Thevar says that the Tatas have still not abandoned him. They still take care of his children’s education, he reveals emotionally.

After the three-day-long siege, the world took notice of the selfless commitment of the Taj employees. As President Obama said in his speech in 2010, the Taj employees ‘risked everything to save human lives’. Their ‘courage and humanity’ were evident in their response to the crisis. Mahavir Singh Rathore sums up what the crisis revealed of Ratan. He says that Ratan is an embodiment of ‘generosity, empathy and compassion’.

What equally astonished the world was how Ratan stepped up to assist all those who were affected by the crisis, giving primacy to human lives over all other considerations. His response demonstrates the ethical standards that underpin the Tata philosophy. In having responded the way he did to the crisis, he may have left behind a parable for the ages.